

Australia is one of the few countries in the world that remains [free of rabies](#).

We have strict biosecurity import conditions to keep Australia rabies free. Rabies is a serious viral disease that affects many animals. It can infect humans and more than 60,000 people die of rabies every year.

Check if you can import your cat or dog

We only allow cats and dogs to be imported from a country approved by us. We refer to this as an 'approved country'.

You must also meet strict import conditions to bring your cat or dog to Australia.

For approved countries that we classify as Group 3, this includes rabies testing and vaccination. This manages the risk of rabies in cats and dogs from these countries.

Group 3 countries are those where rabies is present but well-controlled.

Check how we classify your country. See our [step-by-step guides to import a cat or dog to Australia](#).

Make sure you read the right step-by-step guide.

This page gives advice to help you meet rabies conditions for cats and dogs from Group 3 countries. It is not a detailed list of all import conditions you must meet.

Testing and vaccination

To import a cat or dog from a Group 3 country, you must meet strict conditions relating to rabies. This includes:

- continuous residence in an approved country for at least 180 days before export
- current rabies vaccination
- a valid Rabies Neutralising Antibody Titre test (RNATT)
- a declaration from the competent authority in the country of export.

See the detail in our Group 3 [step-by-step guides to import a cat or dog to Australia](#).

The 180-day waiting period

The 180-day waiting period will ensure your cat or dog is not imported to Australia infected with rabies. Dogs or cats can be infected with rabies without showing signs of rabies disease for up to 180 days after the infection started.

During this time, there is no reliable way to tell if your animal has been infected. You must observe your animal for at least 180 days to see if it develops clinical rabies. This is the only way to tell if an animal has the rabies virus.

The 180 days is not a quarantine period. Your pet can live with you or someone else in an approved Group 3 country during this time.

Vaccination status

You need to maintain valid continuous vaccination status from the time the RNATT sample is taken up to the date of export to Australia.

If your dog or cat is due for a booster vaccination between the RNATT and time of export, it must be given on or before the booster due date. If vaccination status lapses, your cat or dog will be ineligible for export. They will need to be revaccinated, have a new RNATT sample collected and tested, and the 180-day waiting period will restart.

We only accept rabies vaccinations that are approved in the country of export. They must be given according to the manufacturer's instructions. If 2 different brands are used for the primary course, refer to the manufacturer's instructions of the first vaccine in the course.

About the RNATT

This is a blood test that checks if your pet has developed protection against rabies from the vaccinations it was given.

Timing of the RNATT is very important.

Make sure you plan carefully and keep the RNATT valid up to the date of export.

The RNATT is only valid for 12 months or 365 days after the date of blood sampling. You must have a valid RNATT at the time of export to Australia.

You can also reduce quarantine time by getting an [identity check](#) before you get the RNATT.

When to test

The RNATT is performed at least 3-4 weeks after a primary vaccination course is given. This gives time for your cat or dog to develop protection from the rabies vaccine.

If your cat or dog is regularly vaccinated against rabies, you may be able to have the RNATT performed sooner. Check with your vet.

If the rabies vaccine is valid for 3 years, you can perform the RNATT at any time in the 3-year period. If not previously vaccinated, you will still need to wait 3-4 weeks.

Maintain valid test results

The RNATT must remain valid up to the date of export to Australia. It is valid for 12 months from the date the blood sample is taken.

If the RNATT is close to expiring, you must have your pet retested. The blood sample must arrive at the laboratory within 12 months of the original sample. If you do this, you will avoid restarting the 180-day waiting period before export.

Preparing your cat or dog in more than one approved country

It may be possible to start preparations in one approved country but export your pet from another approved country.

Your pet must be continuously resident in an approved country or countries for 180 days immediately prior to export to Australia.

Before you plan to do this, check if the approved government veterinarian will:

- declare that your pet has only resided in an approved country for the 180-day period prior to export date
- accept any preparations completed in another approved country to endorse the veterinary health certificate.

Identity check to reduce quarantine time

An identity check is an optional, recommended step. It reduces the quarantine period for dogs and cats from group 3 countries from a minimum of 30 days to a minimum of 10 days.

It must be completed before the RNATT.

The identity check and RNATT cannot be completed in the same visit.

Only an official government veterinarian can complete an identity check. The identity check is sent directly to us. You do not need a copy of this. Pet agents or shippers cannot provide you with this.

We do not accept any other evidence to verify your animal's identity. For example, a pet passport, vaccination card, or a microchip certificate.

If your pet is already vaccinated against rabies, you can still get the identity check before the blood sample for the RNATT. Talk to your vet about the timing of this.

If your cat or dog is returning to Australia from a Group 3 country, you can use the identity check on your Australian issued export certification.

RNATT declaration

This declaration must be provided with your import permit application.

Most countries have a specific template that the official government veterinarian will be able to provide you. The department will only accept the country-specific RNATT declaration negotiated with approved trading partners.

You request the RNATT declaration from the competent authority in your country of export. An official government veterinarian must complete, sign and stamp the declaration.

To do this, provide them with:

- rabies vaccination certificate
- RNAT test laboratory report.

Documents to provide

When you apply for an import permit, you must provide:

- a copy of the RNATT report issued by the testing laboratory
- the corresponding RNATT declaration, endorsed by the official government veterinarian employed by the competent authority.

This applies to all cat and dog imports from Group 3 countries.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/cats-dogs/rabies-neutralising-antibody>